But most of these changes would finally take shape under a different governor, Raja Man Singh, at the beginning of the next century. For now, Abd un-Nabi and Abdullah Sultanpuri, hearing of the khutba in Mirza Hakim's name, returned to Hindustan from Mecca despite Akbar's express order to the contrary. But the time for indulgence had passed and Akbar had some of the troublesome mullahs quietly killed—Mullah Muhammad Yazdi was drowned in a river, as was Qazi Yaqub from Bengal. The hakim ul-mulk, one of the signatories of the mazhar and a learned and trusted man, but one who was opposed to Abu'l Fazl and who had named him, admittedly in a puerile pun, Abu'l Fuzlah (excrement), was sent to Mecca. Abdullah Sultanpuri died in Gujarat and Qazi Ali was sent to confiscate his property. 'Several boxes full of ingots of gold,' wrote Badauni about the corrupt theologian, 'were discovered in his sepulchre where he had caused them to be buried as corpses.' All these ingots of gold and Abdullah Sultanpuri's precious library were reclaimed by the imperial treasury. Abd un-Nabi returned to Fatehpur Sikri, though the atmosphere at court was hostile towards him. He was rude to the Padshah one day and 'unable to restrain his passion', Akbar struck the mullah in the face. 'Why don't you strike with a knife?' raged the furious mullah in the court where he had once spat on the amirs in his arrogance and pride. Now there was to be no quiet submission by the Padshah and Abd un-Nabi was handed over to Raja Todar Mal and Abu'l Fazl over charges of embezzlement due to a missing amount of 70,000 rupees that Akbar had given the mullahs for distribution in charity at Mecca. A short while later the mullah was strangled in his bed, probably on the order of Abu'l Fazl, who would thereby also have put to rest the demons of his father's ancient humiliations at the hands of these very men, once all-powerful.

Akbar, however, had given clear instructions that all these actions against the ulema had to be carried out 'in such a manner that the ladies should not know of it'. The ulema had the favour of the senior ladies of the harem and Akbar would not have risked their displeasure, for the harem was a formidable force when they acted in concert. There is no doubt that the emperor would have been challenged about decisions and actions which the women considered questionable. Indeed, Abu'l Fazl admitted that Akbar had to be very careful of maintaining all the protocol due to the women of the harem and that he spent three hours in the apartments of the women every afternoon, tending to their various petitions equitably. These petitions